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A COMPLETE GUIDE FOR STUDENTS & PARENTS

Boone Student Housing Playbook

Everything App State families need to rent smart, live well, and invest wisely in the High Country.

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Welcome to the High Country

Finding the right place to live near App State is one of the most important — and stressful — decisions a student or parent can make. Boone's rental market moves fast, inventory is tight, and demand from 21,000+ students keeps pressure on every available unit.

This playbook gives you a clear, step-by-step framework to find, evaluate, and secure the right housing — whether you're a first-year student, a junior looking for more independence, or a parent considering buying investment property near campus.

21,000+
ENROLLED STUDENTS

$1,000–$1,400
AVG. RENT PER ROOM/MO

13 Free
APPALCART ROUTES

Yes
WALK-TO-CAMPUS OPTIONS

Chapter 1: Understanding the Boone Rental Market

The App State Effect

With over 21,000 students enrolled, Appalachian State University drives nearly every aspect of Boone's housing market. Demand consistently outpaces supply, which means students who wait until spring to look for fall housing are already late. The best properties — close to campus, in safe neighborhoods, on a bus route — sign leases in January and February for the following August.

2026 Rental Market: What You'll Pay Per Room

Boone rents have risen steadily. As of early 2026, **per-bedroom rents near App State range from $1,000 to $1,400/month**, depending on proximity to campus, amenities, and property condition. Budget accordingly:

Property Type	Typical Rent/Bedroom	Notes
3–5 BR house near campus	$1,050–$1,255/mo per BR	Highest demand; sign early
1 BR apartment (solo)	$1,050–$1,819/mo	Limited supply near campus
2 BR shared (per person)	$900–$1,100/mo per BR	Good value with right roommate
Luxury student community	$1,200–$1,400/mo per BR	e.g., The Standard at Boone
On AppalCART route (off-campus)	$1,000–$1,200/mo per BR	More options, strong value

> *Pro Tip: Set up alerts on Zillow, Apartments.com, and Facebook Marketplace using Boone, NC as your search area. Properties within a half-mile of campus rent within days of listing.*

When to Start Your Search

- **October–November:** Landlords begin advertising for next year. Good time to assess neighborhoods.
- **December–January:** Peak signing season. Best units are claimed quickly.
- **February–March:** Secondary inventory appears as some deals fall through.
- **April–May:** Slim pickings — mainly sublets and last-minute listings.

Kidd Brewer Stadium and Appalachian State University campus — surrounded by the Blue Ridge Mountains.

Chapter 2: Neighborhoods & Locations

Boone is a compact mountain town, but location matters enormously — especially in winter when snow and ice make driving steep mountain roads challenging.

Near-Campus Options (Walking Distance)

- **Rivers Street / Stadium Drive:** Dense student corridor, high walkability, mix of older homes and newer apartments.
- **Faculty Street / Deerfield:** Quieter residential streets, 10–20 min walk to most buildings.
- **Downtown Boone (King Street area):** Vibrant, walkable, access to restaurants and shops — slightly pricier at $1,300–$1,800/mo for a 1BR.

Bus-Route Communities (AppalCART)

AppalCART operates 13 fare-free routes serving the App State campus and surrounding Boone community. Living on a bus route opens up more affordable options further from campus without sacrificing accessibility.

- All routes are fare-free — no cost to ride any time.
- Routes serve Walmart, Watauga Medical Center, and major shopping corridors.
- Check appstate.edu/transportation for current route maps and schedules.

Chapter 3: What to Look for in a Lease

North Carolina landlord-tenant law provides strong protections — but only if you read your lease carefully before signing.

Lease Item	What to Know
Lease Term	Most Boone student leases run August 1 – July 31. Match to your academic plans.
Security Deposit	NC law caps at 2 months' rent. Get itemized move-in documentation.
Subletting Policy	Study abroad or co-op? Many leases prohibit subletting.
Pet Policy	Clearly stated pet fees and restrictions. Unauthorized pets can cost your deposit.
Utilities Included	Know exactly what's included — internet, water, trash, electric, gas.
Snow/Ice Responsibility	Some leases require tenants to clear walks. In Boone winters, this matters.
Early Termination	Know the exit clause and any buyout costs.

> *Always photograph every room, every wall, and every appliance on move-in day and email photos to your landlord within 24 hours. This single step prevents most security deposit disputes.*

Chapter 4: Budgeting for Off-Campus Life

Off-campus living often costs more than students initially plan. Use this budget framework as a starting point — actual costs will vary.

$1,000–$1,400	$100–$180	$200–$300	$0
RENT (PER BR, 2026)	UTILITIES/MO	GROCERIES/MO	APPALCART BUS

Cost-Saving Strategies

- Split a 3–4 BR house with roommates — per-person cost drops significantly even at today's rates.
- Use AppalCART free bus routes — eliminate car expenses entirely.
- Buy groceries at the Boone Walmart or Food Lion rather than convenience stores.
- Look for utilities-included rentals, especially if usage is unpredictable.

Chapter 5: For Parents — Should You Buy Instead of Rent?

Many App State parents run the numbers and realize that buying a condo or small house near campus can cost less per month than renting — while building equity and creating a potential income property after graduation. With per-bedroom rents now exceeding $1,000/month, the math has never been more compelling.

The Case for Buying

- Your child's rent payments build YOUR equity instead of a landlord's.
- Roommate rent at $1,000–$1,200/bedroom can offset most or all of your mortgage payment.
- Boone property values have appreciated consistently due to constrained supply.
- Post-graduation, the property becomes a long-term rental or vacation asset.

What to Consider

- Buy-and-hold works best for a 4+ year horizon — account for closing costs.
- HOA rules matter — check short-term rental restrictions before buying.
- Work with a local agent who knows the student rental market intimately.

> *I've helped dozens of App State families buy near campus. Call me to run the rent-vs-buy numbers for your specific situation — it's often a clearer decision than families expect.*

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REALTOR®/Broker · Blue Ridge Realty & Investments

Born & raised in Boone · 40+ years High Country experience

App State connected · Community-first approach

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